A month earlier in May, four civilians and a security person had been killed in Punjab. In July 1985, a Memorandum of Settlement was signed between Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and Sant Harchand Singh Longowal of the Shi-romani Akali Dal. The government agreed to make ex-gratia payments to the families of all the innocent people killed since 1982 and pay compensation for damaged property. The government had also agreed to withdraw the Armed Forces Special Powers Act from Punjab and put up a mechanism to expedite militancy related cases. But the accord failed to act as a deterrent to further violence and in the same month, seven civilians were killed.

Now Bharadwaj and Jindal chose a two-part strategy to target Abdul Khan, Sandhu and Sethi. Jindal had suggested that Sethi, being a businessman, could be lured by the agency if they could cultivate enough material to set his life ablaze. For Sandhu and Khan, Jindal suggested a covert operation.

'It all depends on Ahuja's sense of adventure. Has he been able to establish contact with Sethi? He has to stay one step ahead of these rascals,' Bhardwaj said.

Jindal informed him that Ahuja had spoken to Sethi a few days earlier and was planning a trip to California with Sophie, who volunteered to play the role of his girlfriend.

In October 1985, Sophie and Ahuja arrived in San Francisco. Sophie later told Jindal that the first meeting with Sethi took place in a cold atmosphere. 'He was very contemptuous but witty with a sharp intellect/ Sophie said of Sethi.

Despite his initial reluctance, Sethi made Ahuja an offer to stay and work with him in California, which he immediately accepted. Ahuja was also reunited with his old chum, Sethi's